THE GLOBAL FOOTPRINTS

OF R&AW

Since its inception in 1968, the R&AW spies and analysts have been trained to decode not just complex global issues, but also domestic matters with international ramifications. From secret encounters against inimical forces to long-term undercover operations, the R&AW spies gather information which the agency's analysts ensure is polished, put in context, compared with existing information, tested for reliability and then finally disseminated to the customers—India's decision makers, with the prime minister on top of the list.

As per the agency's training manual, there are four stages before a final report is dispatched for action—intelligence collection by field agents, collation at the desk concerned, evaluation and analysis by the analyst and country expert and finally circulation to the customer. While field agents require agility and a light footprint in the target country, analysts must have brains that could beat highspeed computers. The two need to work together to ensure that the intelligence gained is delivered with speed and accuracy.

Five professionally processed reports in this chapter give an insight into the world of intelligence analysts who are rarely mentioned by the media or portrayed in films. Two sections show how espionage operations can sometimes be more dramatic than fiction, and one section describes how the R&AW and the government of the day discuss issues and make decisions. Finally, this chapter also explains the strict rules of